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Sexual solidarity and the secrets of sight and sound

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Okiek cultural identity and initiation: accommodating contradictions

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Okiek cultural identity is characterized by a dialectic of hierarchy and equality, one similar to the tension of Okiek gender relations in some ways but critically different in others. Okiek take their forest life as an essential reference point for their cultural identity, but that life is inextricably woven into the regional network of interethnic relations. Within this wider framework, other ethnic groups place Okiek on the lowest level of status and prestige in a hierarchical understanding of interethnic relations. As a corollary, Okiek are often relegated to a subordinate political status.

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Okiek understand themselves differently, however. They reinterpret and invert the others' views, setting the hierarchical view against a more relativistic one. Yet in essence, Okiek acquiesce to the hierarchy through the inversion. They redefine a dialectic of complementarity and hierarchy, rife with discriminatory values, as one of similarity and difference represented more neutrally. Their relativistic viewpoint, however, has done little to change what is effectively exclusion from discussions that affect them as well as their neighbors.

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Okiek are incorporated into their neighbors' ideologies as a cultural category against which ideal norms, values, and activities central to their neighbors' own senses of cultural identity are defined and illustrated. Okiek are represented as trickster figures: cunning, greedy, unrestrained, and violators

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of accepted standards of social life and behavior in various ways. Okiek seem to disregard what their neighbors view as important relations of respect or nonmarriageability, and they do or eat things that Maasai especially consider abhorrent (Galaty 1977a, 1979, 1986; Kenny 1981; Kratz 1981, 1988b). Their neighbors also consider the very forest habitat of Okiek inhospitable.

Although Kipsigis and Maasai generally represent Okiek similarly, their interpretations and evaluations of them differ significantly. Maasai consider Okiek (under the name Torrobo) intrinsically inferior, despicably degraded by the habits of a hunting life. They regard them with a vehement and thorough contempt that is absent, or at least greatly attenuated, in Kipsigis attitudes.³ Furthermore, Kipsigis interactions with Okiek have rarely been domineering or coercive, as Maasai-Okiek encounters have sometimes been.

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Marriage

A comprehensive consideration of Okiek-Maasai relations during the last century suggests that mutual benefits were relatively balanced or even that Maasai were somewhat more reliant on Okiek than vice versa (cf. Spear 1989:2). Among other things, Okiek fulfilled an essential ritual role as circumcisers and provided necessary ritual products to Maasai (primarily honey but also hyrax capes). Nonetheless, Maasai interpreted their relations with Okiek in terms of goods and services supplied them by inferior, poor, and somehow subordinate neighbors/cousins. In accordance with this pejorative view, Maasai—especially young men—sometimes treated Okiek with an overbearing imperiousness.⁴

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Enduring individual friendships and trade exchanges were often the basis of networks of interethnic interaction. The Okiek perspective emphasizes this fact, stressing mutual benefits through the idiom of "friendship." Encountering Maasai individually or in small groups at ceremonial celebrations or occasionally political meetings, Okiek did and have done little to counter the Maasai impression of Okiek subordination. Joking, apparent or real accommodation, ■452 and a certain diffidence characterize many Okiek interactions with Maasai, whatever the actual balance of goods, services, and reliance.

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³Intermarriage might be taken as one indicator of this difference in attitude. Maasai men marry Okiek women, but there are virtually no recorded cases of Maasai women being given to Okiek men. Kipsigis, on the other hand, not only marry Okiek women, but, as they move into Okiek areas, have recently begun to give their daughters in marriage to Okiek men as well. There are important differences in the economic, ecological, and demographic situations of Maasai and Kipsigis vis-à-vis Okiek today, but these differences in marriage patterns are nonetheless indicative of a difference in attitude as well.

⁴The incidents of individual physical domination or threat that Okiek described to me had almost all taken place before the age-set referred to as *il yangousi* (1950s or so).

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